POWER BI

Stop Learning 50 Power BI Visuals. These 6 Are Enough

The 6 visuals behind almost every business dashboard. For each: when to use it, the settings that matter and the mistake to avoid. Plus which visuals to skip.

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Visual 1: Card

The headline number. Managers read these before anything else.

Use it for

Revenue, orders, margin %, active customers. One number per card.

Settings that matter

Display units in lakhs or crores, 1 decimal place, a short clear label.

Make it better

Add a second card or measure showing change vs last period, coloured green or red.

```
Rev vs LY % = DIVIDE([Revenue] - [Revenue LY],
[Revenue LY])
```

Mistake to avoid

More than 4-5 cards in one row. The eye stops reading them.

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Visual 2: Line chart

Anything over time. The second thing every manager looks at.

Use it for

Monthly revenue, daily orders, weekly active users.

Settings that matter

Date table on the x-axis, continuous type, markers off unless few points.

Make it better

Add last year as a second line, or a constant line for the target.

Mistake to avoid

More than 3-4 lines. Use a slicer to switch category instead.

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Visual 3: Bar chart

Comparing categories. The most useful chart you will ever build.

Use it for

Revenue by region, top 10 products, tickets by team.

Settings that matter

Horizontal bars for long names. Sort descending by value.

Make it better

Top N filter on the visual (Filters pane → Top N) to keep only the top 10.

Mistake to avoid

Sorting alphabetically. Nobody wants to find the biggest bar.

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Visual 4: Matrix

The detail table that answers "show me the numbers behind this".

Use it for

Region by month, product by store, any two-way breakdown.

Settings that matter

Rows and columns hierarchies for drill-down, subtotals on, stepped layout.

Make it better

Conditional formatting: background colour or data bars on the key column.

Mistake to avoid

Using it as the main visual. It belongs at the bottom of the page.

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Visual 5: Slicer

Lets people answer their own questions without asking you for a new report.

Use it for

Date range, region, product category, channel.

Settings that matter

Dropdown style to save space. Between style for dates.

Make it better

Sync slicers across pages (View → Sync slicers) so filters follow the user.

Mistake to avoid

8 slicers on one page. Keep 2-3 and move the rest into the Filters pane.

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Visual 6: Line and column chart

Two measures, one chart. Perfect for actual vs target or volume vs rate.

Use it for

Revenue as columns with margin % as a line. Orders with conversion rate.

Settings that matter

Secondary y-axis for the line. Label both axes clearly.

Make it better

Target as the line, actual as columns. Gaps jump out instantly.

Mistake to avoid

Two measures with the same unit. Use a normal line chart instead.

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Visuals to skip

These look impressive in tutorials and confuse people at work.

- **Pie and donut with many slices**

  Above 3-4 slices, nobody can compare the angles. Use a bar chart.

- **Gauge**

  Takes a lot of space for one number. Use a card with a target comparison.

- **Word cloud**

  Size of words is not a measure people can read. Use a bar chart of counts.

- **3D or heavy custom visuals**

  Hard to read, slow, and often break after updates.

Rule: if a bar chart can show it, use a bar chart.

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Put the 6 on one page

This layout covers most business dashboards.

- **Top**

  3-4 cards: Revenue, Orders, Average order value, Margin %.

- **Left middle**

  Line chart: revenue trend vs last year.

- **Right middle**

  Bar chart: revenue by region, sorted.

- **Bottom**

  Matrix: region by month, with conditional formatting.

- **Side or top-right**

  2-3 slicers: date, category, channel.

- **Second page**

  Line and column chart: actual vs target by month.

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